

UNICEF Eastern and Southern Africa Region

C4D Works!

Evidence-based school governance to achieve greater community engagement and social accountability for education in Namibia



C4D Results

School board training created a turning point for many of the schools under the SASG programme, as it spurred on numerous changes that benefited the school, including an increase in attendance and decrease in bullying. SASG has provided capacity building for school boards and learners participating in Edu-circles, and improved the leadership skills of principals – all of which were considered key to the programme's success. A 2016 study of positive deviant schools found that what makes them different is not their resources or the quality of their teachers or even the charisma of their principal. The key is having a principal who acts as a role model, ensures that the school community is protected against external challenges, fosters a strong team spirit that celebrates high performance and time on task, and aims for constant improvement. Based on these findings, leadership skills were included in the training curricula for principals.

Thanks to the development of and training on social accountability tools, education communities were able to monitor performance management at school and regional level. Teachers, school boards, learners and communities in the 146 pilot schools have gained knowledge on children's rights and civic responsibility. They are also monitoring and taking action against violence in schools.

Thanks to SASG, the Namibian Education Act was revised in a highly consultative process in 2015 to include legal provisions for community participation at school level. The MoEAC has now committed to produce yearly, user-friendly education statistics through the Data Must Speak initiative, a necessary tool to improve social accountability.

Challenges and Lessons Learned

The pilot schools have played a pivotal role in the SASG programme, as they have allowed the MoEAC and development partners to identify strong and weak points in the implementation. Standards have been established to ensure a safe, secure and conducive learning environment, such as the Integrated School Health Programme and the National Safe Schools Framework.

Community engagement and social accountability interventions will remain successful and sustainable if the MoEAC institutionalizes them, integrates them in its standards, and provides regular training and supervision. While the MoEAC has a strong internal accountability framework – having designed a set of seven key performance areas under the National Standards and Performance Indicators – the strength of community participation is not captured in the Education Management Information System. This makes it hard for parents and education stakeholders to monitor how many schools have active school boards and what their impact is on the improvement of schooling.

Changing attitudes, perceptions and norms is difficult in a short period of time. For many years, communities believed that schools were state property and that they had neither a role to play, nor the power to demand accountability. A fundamental change in mindset is required and it implies sustained investment in Communication for Development.



About C4D Works!

C4D Works! shares success stories in Communication for Development (C4D) from Eastern and Southern Africa.

C4D uses research and consultation to promote human rights, mobilize leadership, influence attitudes and social norms, and transform behaviours for the well-being of communities.

In UNICEF, C4D is guided by the socio-ecological model (SEM) which helps identify multiple factors behind a problem in order to address it holistically and sustainably. It also helps to determine which communication approach – advocacy, social mobilization, social change communication or behaviour change communication – will be most effective in addressing the identified problem.



The Issue

While the vast majority of Namibian children attend primary school,¹ the attendance rate falls sharply in secondary school to one in two learners – with considerable disparities between urban and rural areas, between regions and between socio-economic groups.

There are issues on the supply side of education, such as low enrolment in early child development centres, the suboptimal quality of teaching and a lack of adequate equipment. But there are also several concerns on the demand side: parents having low interest in pre-primary education; a significant number of learners being enrolled late in grade 1; many learners not being in the right grade for their age; and a low value being placed on education by some parents. This is especially true for parents from the lower wealth quintile² and those

who are less educated, as well as members of some minority indigenous groups – the San and Ovahimba – and parents of children living with disabilities. Other issues that also play a big role in learners’ absenteeism and their eventual dropping out of school include child labour, early pregnancy, the hidden costs of education, language, violence among learners and from teachers, drug and alcohol abuse, and the stigmatization of disabilities.

Traditionally, school principals are largely seen as holding a position of autocracy, both within schools and in the community. This social position is often associated with both fear and respect; schools are seen as the domain of the school principal, where learners, parents and other community members have little say or influence. This is problematic for two main reasons.



Firstly, caregivers feel that the responsibility for their child’s education lies solely with the school. The second problem is that the school itself is unsupported and unable to benefit from the skills and insights that are available in the community. The school often deals with symptoms of problems that originate within the homes and broader society.

C4D Actions

Between 2011 and 2016, the Namibian Ministry of Education, Arts and Culture (MoEAC) implemented the “Social Accountability and School Governance” (SASG) programme, with support from the UNICEF Namibia Country Office and the European Union. SASG aims to help school communities and other education stakeholders better understand their roles and responsibilities in the management and monitoring of the education system, especially at school level. The programme has worked to build bridges and strengthen relationships between the schools and the communities through a number of interventions targeting different levels of society:

- **Edu-tours:** These high-energy sensitization events make use of the ‘Edu’ character to promote learner governance, social accountability and a stop to bullying;
- Anti-bullying campaign: This nationwide intervention features sensitization meetings on the issue of bullying, with an accompanying media campaign;
- **Edu-circle training:** Edu-circles are learner governance groups that work hand-in hand with the school board, providing a learner-centric stance for decision-making and ensuring that the learners’ voice is heard;
- **School board training:** A practical manual was developed and used to train school boards on their role and responsibilities. It also is a tool that school board members can refer to throughout the year. Prior to the training, many board members were uncertain about their role, legitimacy and mandate.

School profiles for monitoring progress on key supply, demand and learning outcome indicators at all levels were developed to help regional education planners identify the schools most in need and better target the allocation of resources. Building on this, UNICEF Namibia has been implementing the Data Must Speak initiative since 2018, as part of the MoEAC’s wider SASG approach and with the aim of unlocking the potential that data hold for evidence-based decision-making informed by the Education Management Information System. Data Must Speak helps parents, learners and community members analyse data and use them for better management at school level, as well as the better identification, discussion and overcoming of non-school barriers to education. This includes the identification and promotion of “positive deviant”³ schools and community champions for education.

¹ The net enrolment rate is above 97 per cent in grades 1 to 7, according to the 2017 Annual Education Census.
² Global Initiative on Out-of-School Children and Namibia Ministry of Education, Arts and Culture, *School Drop-Out and Out-of-School Children in Namibia: A national review*, UNICEF Namibia Country Office, 2015.
³ Namibia Ministry of Education, Arts and Culture and United Nations Children’s Fund, *Study of Positive Deviant Schools in Namibia*, MoEAC and UNICEF, 2016.